

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

SUNDAY 13 SEPTEMBER 2026 · THE WEEKEND EDITION



A WEEKEND ON THE RESERVE — THE PLATE OF GOLD A FAMILY KEEPS, THE SUIT AND THE MODEL RAILWAY BUILT TO OUTLAST US, AND A KOREAN ISLAND WORTH THE AUTUMN FLIGHT — WHILE DEAR MONEY AND A SECOND OIL GATE WEIGH ON THE WEEK

THE GRAND TOUR

Jeju in autumn — the sunrise peak, the women who dive it, and the island Koreans keep to themselves once the summer crowds go home

THE RABBIT HOLE

Model railways, all the way down: the oval that becomes a world, an open-source command station, and the four-figure brass grail

THE ATELIER

The buy-once suit, from the canvas up — and the pinch test that tells you, in the shop, whether the jacket is glued or built

THIS ISSUE • THE WEEKEND BOOK • NO. 101

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FROM THE DESK

"It is not the man who has too little, but the man who craves more, that is poor."

Seneca, "Letters to Lucilius," Letter II (c. 65 AD)

A week of dear money runs under this issue — a second oil gate contested, a Fed leaning to tighten, gold near its record, and, in the Long Read, tens of millions of Indian families quietly turning inherited gold into working cash. Seneca's line is the reserve's question in nine words. The buy-once desks — the suit, the light-powered watch, the layout built to last — are the same question answered by owning less, better.

THE STRIP • AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE

Brent crude	\$104.61	▲ +8.7% wk
Gold (spot /oz)	\$4,385	▲ bid
Bitcoin	\$77,000	▼ risk-off
VWRA (All-World)	~\$192	▼ soft
US 10-year	4.98%	▲ near 5%
DXV (dollar)	99.2	▲ firm
USD/JPY	156.2	▲ weak yen
STI	5,702	▲ steady

Levels near the 11 Sep close; USD/SGD ~1.267, gold below the 28 Jan record ~\$5,589. Not advice — see **p14**.

THE WEEKEND BOOK • HOW TO READ NO. 101

A weekend issue leans into life without dropping the wire. The hard desks run leaner — the oil war and the pay debate told for what they mean to your Sunday, not your terminal — and the rest is for the coffee: a four-page Travel Desk to Jeju, a three-page descent into model railways, a suit taken apart to its canvas,

and a Long Read from India about the most private asset a household owns. The soft thread is the reserve — the store of value kept against a rainy day, and what it costs to reach for it — running from the Macro Desk's bid for gold to the pawned bangles of the Long Read.

IRAN & THE GULF · THE SECOND GATE, AND A FIRST HINT OF TALKS

Both doors to the oil are contested — then, on Friday, a door opens in Oman

A week that completed the Houthis grip on the Red Sea gate ended on the first genuine de-escalation signal since February: Iran will meet the Gulf states in Muscat on Monday, and Brent gave back three per cent on the news.

this story  

The map closed further before it cracked open. On Friday the Houthis seized Perim — the island in the throat of the Bab-el-Mandeb strait — a day after taking the port of Mocha and the coastal town of Dhubab, giving Iran’s allies effective command of the Yemeni shore of the second gate through which Gulf oil reaches the world.¹ With Hormuz still a shooting war on the opposite flank of Arabia, the week’s picture was a pincer: a hand on both doors at once.¹

The flow numbers told the story better than the map. Transits through Bab-el-Mandeb halved on Friday — fifteen vessels against thirty the day before, three of them running empty — as owners priced a managed closure rather than a single strike.¹ Saudi Arabia shut a major crude pipeline as a precaution after strikes on the kingdom, a repeat of the disruption this desk has tracked since the spring.²

Then the turn. Iranian state media said Tehran would meet the Gulf Cooperation Council states in Muscat on Monday to discuss a temporary arrangement for shipping through Hormuz — the first concrete de-escalation signal in months.² Brent, which had closed above a hundred dollars for the first time since May, settled Friday down two-and-eight-tenths per cent at a hundred and four dollars and sixty-one cents — still up nearly nine on the week, but off its high on the talks headline.²

15

VESSELS THROUGH BAB-EL-MANDEB ON FRIDAY, AGAINST 30 THE DAY BEFORE — THE RISK IS NOW PRICED AS DURATION, NOT A SINGLE STRIKE

DOHA

AL JAZEERA

Files the crisis under a “US-Israel war on Iran”: the attacks “dent hopes” for a Hormuz reopening because Iranian demands cloud the outlook, and the strait stays shut until the underlying war is settled — not bombed. Tehran is a party seeking terms, not the aggressor.

NEW YORK

FOX NEWS

Reads the same week as “Iran-backed terror groups’ latest territorial grab” menacing a second global shipping chokepoint: the Houthis as proxies seizing a gate and threatening Saudi exports, with the case made for force rather than diplomacy.

THE CHATTER

Energy desks read Friday’s fade as the market pricing Monday’s Muscat talks, not any single event on the water — the live premium is the halving of transits, not the headlines. The consensus, per the wire aggregators: treat the Oman meeting as the first off-ramp, and the war premium as reversible the moment flows restore.²

CNBC; Reuters-cited trade-flow data (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

The oil bulls are fighting the forecasters. The US Energy Information Administration still models Brent averaging around ninety dollars in the back half of 2026 — i.e. the premium fades if flows return. Goldman Sachs only sees a hundred and twenty in 2027, and only if Gulf output stays some four million barrels a day below its pre-war level: a conditional, not a base case. Strip the war premium and the fundamentals sit in the low nineties.³

SOURCES 1 — CNBC, France 24, NBC News (11 Sep 2026): Houthis seize Perim, Mocha (10 Sep) and Dhubab, completing the Bab-el-Mandeb takeover; Friday transits 15 vs 30. 2 — CNBC, EnergyNow, Anadolu, Al Jazeera (11–12 Sep): Brent settled \$104.61 (–2.8% day, +8.7% wk), first weekly close >\$100 since May; Saudi pipeline shut; Iran to meet GCC in Muscat Mon 14 Sep. 3 — EIA Short-Term Energy Outlook (~\$90 Brent H2 2026); Goldman Sachs via OilPrice/CNBC (\$120 in 2027 only if output ~4mb/d below pre-war). Wording to confirm against live articles.

UKRAINE · THE PAUSE THAT WASN'T

A three-day truce lapses, and the shuttle diplomacy yields talks, not a ceasefire

The short capital-strike truce that framed last week collapsed on schedule. Russia struck Kyiv on 8 September, killing at least five, hours after the Witkoff-Kushner shuttle passed through Moscow and Kyiv.¹ President Putin rejected an air truce and any front-line pause, still demanding a Ukrainian withdrawal from the rest of the Donbas; the visit produced only an agreement to resume three-way talks, not a stop to the shooting.¹

The delta this week was European money, not diplomacy. The European Commission approved a further seven billion euros for Ukraine to buy air and missile defence, drones and equipment — a signal that Brussels is planning for a long war rather than a near settlement.¹ The pattern is now familiar enough to name: a high-profile envoy visit, a claimed “framework,” a strike within hours, and the front line unmoved — process substituting for progress while the money and the drones keep flowing on both sides.

THE CHATTER

Analysts reading the shuttle see a familiar pattern: a headline meeting, a claimed “framework,” then the front line unmoved. The bear case on a deal is blunt — no settlement while Moscow’s maximal territorial demand stands and Kyiv cannot concede it. Treat “talks resume” as process, not progress.¹

Kyiv Independent; CNN (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC · ON OUR OWN READ

We have called an eventual negotiated pause more than once; it has not come. The honest correction is that every “framework” this year has died on the same rock — the Donbas — and there is no sign that rock has moved. Until a sourced delta says otherwise, assume the war continues.

IN BRIEF · THE WIDER DESK

A cargo jet, an Amazon inquiry. The aftermath of the 6 September crash of a 21 Air Boeing 767-300 freighter at Miami — which overran the runway from San Juan, killing five — widened this week into scrutiny of the operator’s safety culture flying for Amazon, with the US NTSB investigating.²

The dollar’s quiet grip. The week’s oil shock kept the dollar firm and the yen weak — a market read the Macro Desk carries in full (p14): higher-for-longer at the long end, a hundred-and-fifty-six handle on the yen.

The chokepoint tally. Between Hormuz and Bab-el-Mandeb, roughly a fifth of seaborne oil now moves under some threat — the number that has kept a war premium in the crude price since February, and the one Monday’s Muscat talks will be judged against.²

The cargo inquiry widens. Scrutiny of the Miami freighter crash has moved from the runway to the operator: NPR reported growing questions about 21 Air’s safety culture flying for Amazon, with the NTSB’s chair on the investigation — a reminder that the air-cargo boom rides on carriers most passengers never hear of.²

The read-through home. A firmer dollar and a five-per-cent ten-year are the transmission belt from this desk to your portfolio; the Macro Desk turns the same week into a market picture, and a one-line call on gold and the rest (p14).

€7bn

FRESH EU FUNDING APPROVED THIS WEEK FOR UKRAINIAN AIR DEFENCE, DRONES AND KIT — BRUSSELS PLANNING FOR THE LONG WAR

The map closed before it cracked; whether the crack holds is Monday’s question, in Muscat, not Kyiv.

SOURCES 1 — Kyiv Independent, CNN, Al Jazeera, Anadolu (7–12 Sep 2026): Kyiv strike 8 Sep (≥5 dead) after the Witkoff/Kushner shuttle; Putin rejects air truce and front-line pause; EC approves ~€7.1bn for Ukraine. 2 — CNN, NBC, NPR (6–12 Sep): 21 Air/Amazon 767 crash at Miami (5 dead), NTSB investigating; ~20% of seaborne oil under threat across the two straits. Wording to confirm against live articles.

THE HAZE & THE PAY DEBATE · WHAT IT MEANS FOR YOUR SUNDAY

The rain bought back the weekend — but the dry spell isn't finished, and neither is the argument about disclosure

Friday's showers pulled the air back into the healthy band after the first "unhealthy" reading since 2023; and the Workers' Party backed the pay rise while pressing the one demand that actually bites — show us the real numbers.

this story  

Plan the weekend around the dashboard, not the calendar — but this weekend the dashboard cooperated. After the central region's PSI pushed past a hundred earlier this month, the island's first "unhealthy" haze reading in nearly two years, Friday's heavy showers cut one-hour fine-particle levels to the lowest band across all five regions.¹ On the dry ninth of the month the same gauge had read three to four times higher.¹

The reprieve is weather, not a turn in the season. The National Environment Agency's outlook still spans the higher end of moderate into the low end of unhealthy, and forecasters expect hazy days to recur over the coming fortnight as the dry spell runs into October, with smoke drifting from fires in Sumatra and Kalimantan.¹ The sensible play for a family: check myENV before the outdoor hours, keep the big draws — the Mid-Autumn light-up at Gardens by the Bay, the Botanic Gardens heritage weekend — but keep a wet-weather plan in your pocket.¹

The week's other argument was about money, and it turned on a single word. The Workers' Party backed the one-off pay rise of up to nine per cent that takes effect on 15 October — the first increase in roughly fifteen years, lifting the MP allowance to eighteen thousand five hundred dollars — but pressed the Government to disclose ministers' actual total remuneration in a form the public can read, and restated its long-held position that pay be pegged to a multiple of an MP's salary.²

\$5,775

THE 2025 MEDIAN GROSS MONTHLY INCOME — THE NUMBER AGAINST WHICH A \$3.6M PRIME-MINISTERIAL PACKAGE IS READ

THE CHATTER

The reaction online was, in one word, mixed: some threads called the timing "tone-deaf" against slowing growth and workplace disruption, others said a rise is justified if performance follows. SMU's Associate Professor Eugene Tan captured the risk for the record — that the announcement "could come across as being tone-deaf or even self-serving" given the economic mood.²

The Star / FMT (citing social media); Assoc Prof Eugene Tan, SMU

THE SCEPTIC

The defence is structural: Singapore's clean-wage, benchmarked model exists precisely to anchor against graft and talent flight, the raise landed below the review committee's recommendation, and full-remuneration disclosure could invite as much distortion as clarity. On the haze, the honest line is that it is transboundary and largely beyond the island's hand — a recurring seasonal cost, purifiers and N95s and all, not a policy failure.²

STILL ON THE SHELF

Age-assurance law. The social-media age checks flagged at the National Day Rally advance to legislation in early 2027 — the Family Desk carries the detail and the evidence (p12).

SOURCES 1 — NEA advisories (9 & 11 Sep 2026); Malay Mail, Mothership (11–12 Sep): PSI eased to moderate across all regions after Friday rain (one-hour PM2.5 Band 1); dry spell and recurring haze expected into October; Sumatra/Kalimantan fires. 2 — The Star, AsiaOne, FMT (9–10 Sep): WP backs up-to-9% raise (effective 15 Oct; MP allowance → \$18,500) but presses for total-remuneration disclosure and pegging to an MP multiple; 2025 median gross income \$5,775; Assoc Prof Eugene Tan (SMU). Wording to confirm against live articles.

BUY IT ONCE • THE SUIT, FROM THE CANVAS UP

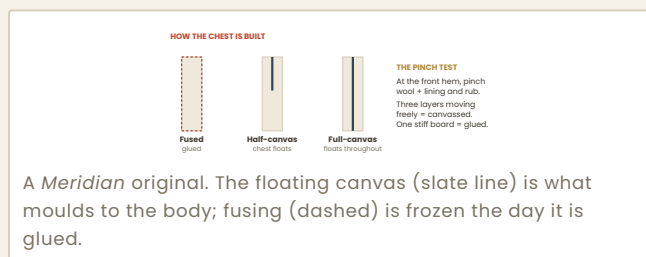
A jacket is not fabric — it is fabric hung on a skeleton, and the skeleton is the whole game

Learn one thing — how the chest is built — and you can judge any suit on any rack, cold. Then learn one number, the weight, and buy the only suit Singapore needs.

this story  

There are three ways to give a jacket's chest and lapels their shape, and they set price and lifespan before a stitch of style is added.

Fused: an interlining is glued to the wool by machine — cheap, and prone to *delamination*, the blistered “bubbling” that heat, sweat and solvent bring on faster.¹ **Half-canvas:** a floating canvas runs through the chest and lapels, fused below — the honest mainstream choice. **Full-canvas:** a stitched, floating canvas through the whole front, so the jacket moulds to you and fits better after a decade than on day one.¹



Cloth is the second lesson, and marketing lies here first. The “Super” numbers measure the *fineness* of the fibre, not quality: higher is more delicate, shinier, shorter-lived, and 150s-and-up feel gorgeous and wilt. The spec that matters is the one nobody quotes — the weight. In Singapore you want the lightest cloth that still drapes: a high-twist, open-weave **fresco** (Minnis, Crispaire, Fox Air), or linen, in the seven-to-nine-and-a-half-ounce band.²

The makers, by tier. The entry of quality is real canvas — Suitsupply's ready-to-wear from about five hundred and fifty US dollars, often in VBC cloth, with a store at ION Orchard (full canvas a hundred-dollar upgrade on its made-to-measure).² The sweet spot is made-to-measure — Ring Jacket about twelve hundred and fifty US dollars in Japan; in Singapore, Edit Suits and CYC The Custom Shop from the mid hundreds to nine hundred Singapore dollars.³ Bespoke climbs from Whitcomb & Shaftesbury's

India-made “Classic Bespoke” near three thousand two hundred pounds to the Row and Naples — Anderson & Sheppard, Huntsman and Rubinacci from roughly forty-six-hundred pounds or euros, over months of fittings.³

THE CHATTER • THE WHITE-LABEL TRUTH

VBC weaves roughly half its output under other brands' names — its largest customer is Zegna — so a “house cloth” with no bunch number is often unbadged Biella marked up. Much designer tailoring is contract-made by factories such as Caruso, then sold fused at bespoke money. The forums say it plainly: buy the maker, not the logo.⁴

Permanent Style; StyleForum; Caruso / VBC

THE SCEPTIC

Where the price is theatre: the Super-number arms race sells fragility as luxury; “bespoke” is routinely stuck on made-to-measure (ask — an individual paper pattern, or an adjusted block?); and for a standard body a good made-to-measure gives about ninety per cent of bespoke at a third of the price. The tropical verdict: one or two canvassed fresco suits, well kept, outlast a rack of glued designer ones.²

The buy-once case: air a suit a day between wears, brush it (moths hate a brushed cloth), steam not press, dry-clean twice a year at most, store it dehumidified — and it lasts decades.¹

NEXT ON THE BENCH • YOU PICK THE CATEGORY

Copper & stainless cookware — clad vs solid copper, tin vs steel linings, the OEM truth behind the five-ply pan.

Glassware & stemware — mouth-blown vs machine-pulled, and the cheap tumbler that's secretly a famous maker.

Coffee grinders — burr geometry as the whole game, and which “premium” grinders share one burr set.

SOURCES 1 — Permanent Style, Bespoke Unit, Café Costume: fused/half/full-canvas construction, delamination, the pinch test, care/longevity. 2 — Nathan Tailors, Cutting Room Bespoke (Super numbers 110s–130s sweet spot); Luxire/Styleforum on fresco (Minnis, H&S Crispaire, Fox Air, Smith Finmeresco); Suitsupply canvas journal + ION Orchard store. 3 — Permanent Style (Ring Jacket MTM ~US\$1,250; W&S Classic Bespoke ~£3,200; Rubinacci ~€4,800); Steed/Huntsman/A&S price lists; Edit Suits & CYC (SG) published pricing. 4 — VBC (Zegna its largest customer; ~half output white-labelled); Caruso heritage; Permanent Style/StyleForum consensus. Some Row/Naples figures are recent-but-not-current; confirm direct before acting.

THE SUMMIT CLOCK · XI TO WASHINGTON, 24 SEPTEMBER

The twenty-five-per-cent chip deal is delivering almost nothing — and China's own silicon is scaling to fill the gap

With Xi Jinping bound for Washington in a fortnight and Nvidia's China business the top item, the reopened H200 channel has become a stalemate neither side is filling — while Huawei and Cambricon ship the domestic stack.

this story  

The deal was supposed to reopen the market. Late last year Washington cleared Nvidia to ship its more advanced H200 to China provided the US Treasury took a quarter of the proceeds — a levy on the sale of a chip.¹ By late summer it was clear the channel had stalled from the other side: Beijing restricted purchases, only a fraction of permitted volume shipped, and Nvidia excluded China data-centre compute from its outlook, its new-shipment share into the country collapsing from the mid-nineties in percentage terms toward zero.¹ A November mandate requiring state-funded data centres to use only domestic chips is the reason the licence buys so little.¹

Into that gap, the home stack is scaling faster than the datasheets suggested. Huawei used September to lay out an Ascend roadmap — the 950, 960 and 970 rolling through 2028 — with the 950PR already shipping in volume: a claimed hundred-and-twenty-eight gigabytes of memory and, on Huawei's own numbers, close to three times the inference throughput of the throttled H20 per card.² Cambricon, the Shanghai-listed rival, reported first-half revenue of six billion yuan and put its dual-die SiYuan 690 into mass production; analysts now project domestic accelerators supplying roughly ninety per cent of China's market.²

160,000

ASCEND 950DT ACCELERATORS DEEPSEEK IS REPORTED TO HAVE ORDERED FOR A GIGAWATT-SCALE INNER MONGOLIA CLUSTER — THE DEMAND SIGNAL UNDER THE ROADMAP

THE CHATTER

The demand under the roadmap is real: DeepSeek is reported to have ordered a hundred and sixty thousand of Huawei's coming 950DT parts for a gigawatt-scale Inner Mongolia data centre, potentially the largest Ascend cluster yet. The read on the desks: the summit will trade chips against rare earths and EV tariffs, but the structural story is that China is building to not need the trade.²

Big Hat Group “China AI Weekly”; TrendForce (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

Read the vendor numbers as vendor numbers. “Nearly three times the H20” and “ninety per cent domestic” are Huawei-and-analyst figures, not independent benchmarks; Ascend's real ceiling is still software parity with Nvidia's CUDA, not raw specification. And the quarter-cut H200 deal looks less like a reopening than a stalemate neither side is filling — a licence that ships almost nothing.¹

STILL ON THE SHELF

DeepSeek's listing, further out. The Shanghai STAR listing this desk flagged advances only in the fine print: the FT reports founder Liang Wenfeng is personally screening investors to keep control, and the Wall Street Journal now pegs the debut to 2027 — paperwork moving, the IPO itself receding.³

The frontier, still split. OpenAI shipped a proprietary frontier model on 3 September; the open-weight top tier stays almost entirely Chinese — DeepSeek, Zhipu, Moonshot, Alibaba's Qwen — which the Home Lab picks up overleaf (p8).³

SOURCES 1 — CNBC (Feb, Aug 2026): H200 cleared with a 25% US cut; Beijing restricts purchases, Nvidia excludes China DC compute; Nov-2025 domestic-chip mandate for state data centres. 2 — Big Hat Group, TrendForce, Tom's Hardware (Sep 2026): Huawei Ascend 950/960/970 roadmap, 950PR shipping (128GB, ~2.87x H20 claimed); Cambricon H1 rev RMB6bn, SiYuan 690 mass production; ~90% domestic-share projection; DeepSeek 160k 950DT order. 3 — FT, WSJ via QZ/InsideAI (9 Sep): DeepSeek investor screening, listing pegged 2027; OpenAI proprietary frontier model 3 Sep. Vendor performance figures are self-reported; treat as claims.

THE HOME LAB · THE WEIGHTS DROP, THE BOXES ARRIVE

DeepSeek's V4.1-Flash lands with open weights — and IFA hands the high-end home lab a router and two memory monsters

The fresh drop is a genuinely local model. DeepSeek released V4.1-Flash on 10 September — the smallest member of its new architecture, with native visual understanding — under an ungated MIT licence, advancing the V4-Flash line this desk has tracked.¹ On paper it is a five-hundred-and-fifty-two-billion-parameter mixture-of-experts model, but only eight to sixteen billion parameters are active at a time, plus aggressive cache compression and a context window up to a million tokens.¹

The point for a home lab is what that makes runnable. The full snapshot is about five hundred and ten gigabytes, but community quantisations already exist: a three-bit build lands near a hundred and three gigabytes — enough to run on a box with a hundred-and-ten-gigabyte memory budget — and an eight-bit build near a hundred and sixty-two.¹ This is not a single-card model; it is precisely a high-end home-lab model, which is where the reader lives.

~103 GB

SIZE OF THE 3-BIT V4.1-FLASH BUILD — A 552-BILLION-PARAMETER BRAIN SQUEEZED ONTO A SERIOUS DESKTOP

THE HARDWARE, FROM IFA 2026

NVIDIA PAIR — a free, open-source “personal AI router” announced 3 September that discovers compatible PCs on your home network and routes inference to whichever GPU has capacity, enabling parallel agentic work fully offline; it hooks into Ollama and LM Studio at launch.²

NVIDIA RTX Spark (the NIX) — an October window: a Grace-plus-Blackwell desktop with up to a hundred and twenty-eight gigabytes of unified memory and roughly a petaflop of compute, a natural host for V4.1-Flash at three to four bits.²

Minisforum MS-S1 — an AMD Ryzen AI Max+ workstation with up to a hundred and ninety-two gigabytes of unified memory, a hundred and sixty of it allocatable as graphics

memory: enough for the hundred-gigabyte quant with headroom for context.²

THE CHATTER

On r/LocalLLaMA and the quant repos the enthusiasm is for the active-parameter trick — a big brain that runs fast because most of it sleeps between tokens — and for PAIR as the missing piece for people with two or three boxes rather than one. The recurring caution: the full expert set still has to live somewhere fast.¹

r/LocalLLaMA; Hugging Face quant threads (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

The bottleneck on these unified-memory boxes is memory *bandwidth*, not capacity: a hundred-and-ninety-two-gigabyte machine will *load* a hundred-gigabyte mixture-of-experts model, but tokens-per-second on long context is the real question, and “a hundred and thirty-one TOPS” is a marketing aggregate, not sustained throughput. And the benchmark scores circulating for V4.1-Flash are quoted from the older V4-Flash build, not independently confirmed for this release. Buy-once buyers should wait for real numbers on this model.¹

The shape of the practical home lab has changed with these releases, and it is worth naming for anyone about to spend. The old choice was a wall of second-hand data-centre GPUs, loud and power-hungry; the new one is a single quiet box with a very large unified-memory pool, into which a low-bit quant of a frontier-class open model now fits. That is a genuinely different proposition — a frontier brain on a desk, offline, under your own keys — but the honest advice is to buy the memory, not the marketing: the model that runs today is the three-bit quant, the experience is gated by bandwidth, and the software stack around a mixture-of-experts server is still where the friction lives.¹

SOURCES 1 — ccleaks, MindStudio, Kingy AI, Hugging Face (10 Sep 2026): DeepSeek-V4.1-Flash, MIT/ungated, 552B MoE (8B prefill/16B decode active), 1M context, ~510GB BF16; community quants (3-bit ~103GB, 8-bit ~162GB); benchmark numbers carried from V4-Flash-0731, unconfirmed for 4.1. 2 — AI Weekly, Tom's Hardware (IFA 2026, 3–9 Sep): NVIDIA PAIR (free/OSS, Ollama/LM Studio); RTX Spark NIX (Grace+Blackwell, up to 128GB unified, ~1 PFLOP, Oct); Minisforum MS-S1 (Ryzen AI Max+, up to 192GB unified / 160GB allocatable). Vendor throughput figures are marketing aggregates.

GEAR WE'RE WATCHING · THE ANTI-DISPOSABLE HEADPHONE

A wireless can you can actually fix — Beyerdynamic bets a buy-once reader will pay for a replaceable battery

Most wireless headphones die the day their glued-in battery does. The Aventho Y, launched at IFA, ships with a user-replaceable battery, magnetic ear cushions and ninety hours of play — the buy-once case, at a mainstream price.

this story  

The quiet defect of the wireless headphone is that it is a consumable pretending to be a purchase: the lithium cell sealed inside loses its charge over a few years, and because you cannot replace it, the whole thing becomes landfill. Beyerdynamic's Aventho Y, shown at IFA and on sale from 3 September at about a hundred and fifty US dollars, is a small rebellion against that — a closed-back wireless pair with active noise cancelling whose battery the owner can swap, whose ear cushions attach by magnet, and which runs a claimed ninety hours on a charge over Bluetooth 6.0.¹

For a reader who thinks in decades, the specification that matters is not the driver but the design: a part that fails is a part you can renew, which is the whole buy-once argument moved from a suit or a pen to a gadget. The company frames it as headphones made “less disposable,” and the reviewers who handled it at the show read the ninety-hour figure and the repair story as the genuine hook rather than the sound.¹

90 hrs

CLAIMED BATTERY LIFE — AND, UNUSUALLY, A BATTERY YOU CAN REPLACE WHEN THAT NUMBER FINALLY FADES

WIRELESS ANC

REPLACEABLE BATTERY

IFA 2026

THE CHATTER

The show-floor read (Android Headlines, WiFi HiFi, ecoustics) is that the repairability carries it — user-serviceable batteries and magnetic pads are rare at any price, rarer at this one — and that Beyerdynamic's house sound and comfort carry the rest. The caveat in the same coverage: at a hundred and fifty dollars this is a mainstream can, not a flagship, and the ANC and app are judged against that.¹

Android Headlines; WiFi HiFi; ecoustics (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

“Repairable” is only worth paying for if the parts actually exist in three years — the graveyard of modular gadgets is full of promised spares that never shipped, so the honest test is whether Beyerdynamic stocks the battery a decade out, not whether the hatch opens today. And for pure sound-per-dollar this is a competent mainstream can, not an endgame; a buy-once reader chasing the last ten per cent of audio still looks up the ladder.¹

STILL ON THE SHELF

Nothing Headphone (1) Pro — tipped for a 29 September launch at a reported three hundred and ninety-nine dollars with a triple-driver, xMEMS-assisted setup; unannounced, so watch, don't buy.²

RayNeo iO — the camera-free display glasses this desk covered at launch are now shipping; no new peg, so a line, not a lead (see No. 96).²

Plaud One — the AI recording earbuds with a 4G case are up for pre-order at about two hundred and fifty dollars, shipping in the fourth quarter — a device to track, not yet a buy.²

SOURCES 1 — Android Headlines, WiFi HiFi, ecoustics, Gear Diary (IFA 2026, 3 Sep): Beyerdynamic Aventho Y, ~US\$149.99, closed-back wireless ANC, user-replaceable battery, magnetic ear cushions, Bluetooth 6.0 multipoint, ~90h battery, four colours; framed as “less disposable.” 2 — Gizmochina/iTechPost (Nothing Headphone (1) Pro leak, ~\$399, ~29 Sep); Meridian No. 96 (RayNeo iO shipping, no new peg); TechCrunch/Engadget (Plaud One, ~\$249.99, Q4 pre-order). Product image: representative Beyerdynamic over-ear headphone (see caption); a direct Aventho Y press image could not be isolated for this build.

OBJECTS & ESCAPES · FIFTY YEARS OF LIGHT

The watch that never needs winding, or a battery, turns fifty — and Citizen marks it with paper and light

Eco-Drive is the quiet buy-once story in watches: a movement powered by any light, sealed for decades, needing nothing. For its half-century Citizen offers a hand-dyed Japanese-paper dial in titanium, and a new light-powered calibre.

this story  

There is a case to be made that the most quietly radical watch a person can own is not mechanical at all. Citizen's Eco-Drive, fifty years old this year, runs on any light — sun, a lamp, a window — storing charge in a cell the owner is never meant to open or replace; no winding, no battery swaps, no service ritual for years on end.¹ For a buy-once reader who reveres Grand Seiko's hand-winds, it is the opposite argument made equally well: a thing engineered to ask nothing of you.

The anniversary pieces split the difference between craft and science. The Citizen Eco-Drive 50th Anniversary Edition sets a hand-dyed *washi* paper dial — the green of pine needles, dyed yellow with a traditional plant dye then dipped in indigo — in a lightweight Super Titanium case, limited to six hundred and fifty pieces at three thousand and ninety-five US dollars.¹ Alongside it, the Eco-Drive Photon range translates the science of light into a layered technical dial and a new light-powered movement, limited to five thousand pieces, arriving this autumn from nine hundred and ninety-five dollars in titanium, or eleven ninety-five in the black-and-gold execution.¹

±15 s/mo

THE EVERYDAY ECO-DRIVE STANDARD — AND, AT THE TOP OF THE HOUSE, THE LIGHT-POWERED CALIBER 0100 HOLDS ±1 SECOND A YEAR

LIGHT-POWERED **SUPER TITANIUM** **BUY-ONCE**

THE CHATTER

The enthusiast read (Watchonista, WatchTime, Monochrome) is that Citizen is doing something more interesting than a logo re-issue — a washi dial is a genuine piece of Japanese craft, and the house's light-powered Caliber 0100, accurate to a second a year, is a real horological flex that the anniversary quietly stands on. The affection is for the technology's honesty: a watch that just works.¹

Watchonista; WatchTime; Monochrome Watches (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

Three thousand dollars for a quartz watch — however clever the movement or lovely the paper — will read as a lot to anyone who prices watches by mechanism, and the collector market prizes the tick of a balance wheel over the silence of a photodiode. The honest defence is that you are buying the dial and the fifty-year story, not the timekeeping, which a hundred-dollar Eco-Drive already nails. Above that, you pay for craft and scarcity, the same as anywhere.¹

The escape, for once, is the object itself: a watch that survives being left in a drawer, charges from the window it sits by, and asks for nothing on a trip where a mechanical piece would wind down or a battery die. It is the least demanding luxury in the case — which, for a reader weighing what to actually reach for on a Sunday, is close to the whole point.

STILL ON THE SHELF

Zenith Chronomaster Solo Sport. The time-only five-hertz El Primero this desk covered at its Geneva launch now has hands-on verdicts in — reviewers rate the manufacture movement and the new clasp, and gripe, uniformly, about the near-ten-thousand-dollar price for three hands. A delta, not a lead (see No. 95).¹

SOURCES 1 — Citizen Watch Global newsroom; Watchonista, WatchTime, Monochrome, Notebookcheck (2026): Eco-Drive 50th Anniversary Edition (AQ4091-56W, hand-dyed washi dial, Super Titanium, 650 pieces, US\$3,095); Eco-Drive Photon 50th Anniversary (5,000 pieces, autumn, US\$995 Ti / US\$1,195 black-gold); Eco-Drive light-power fundamentals; Caliber 0100 (±1s/year). Product image: representative Citizen Eco-Drive titanium watch (see caption); a direct press image of the specific new reference could not be isolated for this build.

CULTURE DESK · THE LIDO HANDS OUT ITS LION

“Woman Unknown” takes the Golden Lion, Malkovich the actor’s cup — and our own call comes good

Venice closed on Saturday with the Golden Lion to May el-Toukhy’s post-war thriller and a rare double for its lead; the festival’s loudest ovation, and John Malkovich’s prize, went to the film we said would not win it.

this story  

The eighty-third Venice Film Festival gave its Golden Lion on Saturday to *Woman Unknown*, the Danish director May el-Toukhy’s post-war psychological thriller — a rare double, with its lead, Mathilde Arcel, also taking the Volpi Cup for Best Actress, the exception the rules allow for a Lion winner.¹ Lee Chang-dong’s *Possible Love* took the Grand Jury Prize, Ilya Khrzhanovsky the directing Silver Lion, and George Clooney a lifetime Golden Lion.¹

The festival’s loudest room, though, belonged to a film that left with an acting prize rather than the top one. Martin McDonagh’s *Wild Horse Nine* — John Malkovich and Sam Rockwell as CIA officers on Easter Island on the eve of the 1973 Chilean coup — drew the first raucous ovation of the competition, and Malkovich the Volpi Cup for Best Actor; it reaches cinemas in November.¹ This desk predicted in No. 98 that the Lion would *not* go to it. It did not — the call comes good, graded on the Scoreboard next Saturday.

83rd

EDITION OF THE VENICE FESTIVAL — A GOLDEN LION AND A BEST ACTRESS FROM ONE FILM, THE RULES’ SINGLE PERMITTED DOUBLE

THE CHATTER

The trade read (*Variety*, *Hollywood Reporter*, *Deadline*) framed el-Toukhy’s win as a jury rewarding control over spectacle, and McDonagh’s ovation as the festival’s momentum story into awards season. A special jury prize went to a Gaza documentary that drew a record standing ovation — the room’s politics as much as its taste.¹

Variety; The Hollywood Reporter; Deadline (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

The standing-ovation stopwatch is festival theatre, not a quality metric: Venice ovations are notoriously inflated and correlate poorly with either the Lion or an eventual Oscar. Treat “stormed into the awards race” as trade-press momentum, not a verdict — the film that owns the room in September is often not the one holding a statue in March.¹

ON THE RECORD PLAYER

Kasabian, “Act III.” The Leicester band’s ninth, out 4 September, pivots disco-ward; Clash scored it eighty, fans ran cooler — the usual critics-warmer-than-listeners split.²

Neil Young & the Chrome Hearts, “Second Song.” Out 18 September, Young’s fiftieth studio album — a seven-track, semi-acoustic set with two 1960s songs unreleased until now: a natural vinyl pre-order for the reader who still buys the record.²

50th

NEIL YOUNG’S STUDIO-ALBUM COUNT WITH “SECOND SONG” — A WORKING ARTIST AT EIGHTY, STILL CUTTING TO TAPE

The wider read on this Venice is that the festival is once again a launchpad rather than a destination: two of its prizes — a control-over-spectacle Lion and a career actor’s cup for a film everyone is talking about — set up a long awards season that Toronto and the guilds will now reshape. For a viewer, the useful takeaway is a shortlist to watch: *Woman Unknown* when a distributor picks it up, and *Wild Horse Nine* in November, where the ovation meets the box office.¹

SOURCES 1 — Euronews, *Variety*, *Indiewire*, *Hollywood Reporter*, *Deadline*, *La Biennale* (12 Sep 2026): Golden Lion *Woman Unknown* (May el-Toukhy); Volpi Best Actress Mathilde Arcel; Grand Jury Prize Lee Chang-dong *Possible Love*; Best Director Ilya Khrzhanovsky; Volpi Best Actor John Malkovich (*Wild Horse Nine*, McDonagh, ~13-min ovation, Nov release); lifetime Lion George Clooney; special jury prize to a Gaza documentary. Meridian No. 98 predicted the Lion would not go to *Wild Horse Nine*. 2 — Clash, Album of the Year (Kasabian *Act III*, 4 Sep, ~80 critic score); Wikipedia/RIFF (Neil Young *Second Song*, 18 Sep, 50th album).

RAISING THEM WELL • THE LAW ARRIVES, THE EVIDENCE COMPLICATES IT

Singapore is about to draw a line under thirteen — and the research on what phone rules actually do is messier than the headline

Age-assurance becomes law in early 2027: under-thirteens blocked, teens kept only where platforms behave. The best 2026 evidence on school phone bans, though, says the effect on learning is close to zero — useful to know for a girl starting secondary school.

this story  

The policy that was trailed at the National Day Rally now has an edge to it. Singapore will legislate mandatory age assurance in early 2027: under-thirteens blocked from designated social-media services, thirteen-to-seventeens kept on only where platforms provide an age-appropriate experience — age checks, daily time limits, and curbs on infinite scroll, autoplay and messages from strangers.¹ Six services have been engaged, and the Government says it intends to go beyond them; the “raise the age to eighteen” line that circulated is a penalty on non-compliant platforms, not a new default entry age.¹

For a parent it reads as a floor arriving under the household — welcome, but not a substitute for the norms you set at home. And the evidence on the nearest comparable lever, phone rules at school, is more sobering than the campaign for them suggests.

A 2026 US study from the National Bureau of Economic Research found the average effect of school cellphone restrictions on test scores close to zero — modest gains in high schools, especially in maths, small negatives in middle schools.² A Florida working paper found score gains and fewer unexcused absences, strongest in the second year after an adjustment period. Bans clearly cut in-class phone use, but produced a short-term rise in suspensions that faded after a year, and no consistent evidence that they reduce bullying.²

The Singapore law is more ambitious than a school ban in one respect: it puts the burden on the platforms, not the pupil. Age assurance, daily time limits and curbs on the design features that keep a

child scrolling — infinite feeds, autoplay, messages from strangers — are exactly the levers the evidence keeps pointing back to, because they act on the thing that displaces sleep and friendship rather than on the child holding the phone. Whether it works will depend on enforcement against services that would rather not comply, which is why the Government has signalled it intends to go beyond the initial six.¹

2027

WHEN SINGAPORE'S AGE-ASSURANCE LAW TAKES EFFECT — A FLOOR UNDER THE HOUSEHOLD, ARRIVING AS THIS YEAR'S COHORT ENTERS SECONDARY SCHOOL

~0

AVERAGE EFFECT OF SCHOOL PHONE BANS ON TEST SCORES IN THE 2026 NBER STUDY — REAL FOR BEHAVIOUR, MUTED FOR GRADES

THE CHATTER

On the parenting boards — Mumsnet's pre-teen and secondary threads — the recurring moves for an entering-secondary girl are a first phone kept deliberately dumb (“travel and group chat only”) and parent pacts to delay smartphones together, so no child is the lone hold-out. The transition anxiety, not the device, is what the threads keep circling.³

Mumsnet (Preteens / Secondary boards, 2026); YoungMinds (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC • ON THE PANIC

The contrarian case, carried overleaf in full, is that the strong “screens are rewiring children” claim outruns its evidence — and that a ban treated as a cure can distract from the levers that actually hold up: sleep, in-person friendship, and physical activity (p13). Label all of this general guidance, not medical advice.

SOURCES 1 — Mothership, MustShareNews, Biometric Update (Aug 2026): Singapore mandatory age assurance early 2027 — under-13 blocked, 13-17 age-appropriate access, six services engaged; penalties on non-compliant platforms. 2 — NBER (2026), Stanford REAP/Florida working paper, NPR (May 2026): average school phone-ban effect on scores ~zero (HS gains, MS small negatives); behaviour effects real; suspensions rose short-term; no consistent bullying reduction. 3 — Mumsnet Preteens/Secondary boards (2025-26); YoungMinds transition guidance. General guidance, not medical advice.

THE TWEEN YEARS · THE CASE AGAINST THE PANIC

Two 2026 studies point opposite ways — so lead with the levers the evidence agrees on

The screen-time research this year refuses to settle, which is itself the useful finding. A January 2026 study in a *Nature*-portfolio journal analysed more than fifty thousand American children and teenagers and linked higher screen time to anxiety, depression and behaviour problems — but with sleep and physical activity as mediators, meaning screens did their harm partly by displacing rest and movement.¹ A 2026 University of Manchester study, meanwhile, found no evidence that heavier social-media use or gaming increased anxiety or depression over the following year.¹

The developmental psychologist Candice Odgers has become the sharpest voice against the strong claim: her longitudinal data finds social media does not predict later depression — rather, already-struggling girls use it more, a direction-of-causation trap — and she has written in *Nature* that the idea technology is “rewiring” children’s brains is not supported by the science.² The most rigorous challenges to strong-effect claims, from Amy Orben and Andrew Przybylski, point the same way.²

Notice what the two studies that seem to disagree actually share: even the alarming one found the harm ran *through* sleep and physical activity. That is the practical gift buried in a messy literature — the mechanism is the lever. A phone that steals an hour of sleep or displaces a training session does measurable damage; the same phone used after homework, in a shared space, with the notifications off, looks very different in the data. The device is not the variable so much as what it crowds out.¹

WHAT A WELLNESS-MINDED HOUSEHOLD CAN ACTUALLY DO

Guard the bedtime first — it is the single most evidence-backed lever, and the one a parent controls. Keep the phone

out of the bedroom overnight; the “charges in the kitchen” rule does more than any app timer.¹

Make the first phone a tool, not a feed — calls, maps and a group chat before an algorithmic timeline; the coming law makes that the platforms’ job too, but the household norm arrives years earlier.¹

Protect the sport and the friendships — in-person time and movement are where the firm evidence sits; defend them and most of the screen question answers itself.¹

Protect sleep, in-person friendship and physical activity first — those have the firmest evidence. A ban is a floor, not a cure.

50,231

CHILDREN IN THE JANUARY 2026 SCREEN-TIME STUDY — THE HARM RAN THROUGH SLEEP AND ACTIVITY, WHICH IS WHERE THE LEVER IS

THE CHATTER

The synthesis parents actually use: treat the coming law as a backstop, keep the phone a tool rather than a feed, and defend the three things the evidence agrees on — consistent bedtimes, real-world friendship and sport. For a wellness-minded household these are the levers already valued; the device is downstream of them.¹

Nature-portfolio (Jan 2026); Manchester (2026); parenting-forum synthesis

THE SCEPTIC

Don’t over-correct into complacency either. “No proven catastrophe” is not “no problem” — the honest position is uncertainty, and uncertainty argues for moderation over both alarm and laissez-faire. The one thing the whole field agrees on is that sleep loss is real and measurable; guard that, and you are acting on the strongest evidence in the room. General guidance, not medical advice.²

SOURCES 1 — *Humanities & Social Sciences Communications* (Nature portfolio, Jan 2026; 50,231 US children, screen time linked to anxiety/depression with sleep & activity as mediators); University of Manchester (2026, no increase in anxiety/depression from heavier social-media/gaming). 2 — Candice Odgers (NPR Jun 2026; *Nature* commentary; longitudinal cohort); Amy Orben & Andrew Przybylski (pre-registered studies). General guidance, not medical advice.

THE BIG PICTURE · DEAR MONEY

An oil-shock reflation meets a Fed expected to hike — and the ten-year knocks on five per cent

One supply-driven force is running through every instrument this week: a spiking oil price is colliding with a central bank leaning to tighten, pushing long yields toward five, keeping the dollar firm, and pressuring risk while gold holds its bid.

this story  

BRENT \$104.61	US 10-YR 4.98%	GOLD / OZ \$4,385	BITCOIN ~\$77k	DXY 99.2	USD/JPY 156.2
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The regime this week has a name: oil-shock reflation meeting higher-for-longer. A supply-driven crude spike — Brent's first weekly close above a hundred dollars since May, even after Friday's fade to a hundred and four sixty-one — is colliding with a Federal Reserve that markets expect to raise rates at its 15–16 September meeting, not cut.¹ Fed-funds futures and prediction markets put the odds of a quarter-point hike to three-and-three-quarters-to-four per cent anywhere from about seventy to ninety per cent, on a hot August inflation print — headline up four-tenths on the month, three-and-four-tenths on the year — and a hawkish tone from the chair.¹

The mechanism is a chain, not a list. A war premium in oil feeds an inflation scare; a Fed expected to tighten pushes the ten-year Treasury yield toward five per cent, its highest in years; a firm real yield keeps the dollar bid, with the yen out past a hundred and fifty-six; and a firmer dollar and higher yields press on equities, so a global all-world index sits soft near a hundred and ninety-two.² The European Central Bank had already hiked to two-and-a-half per cent on 10 September — three banks, one direction.²

~70–90%

MARKET-IMPLIED ODDS OF A FED HIKE THIS WEEK — THE PAIN TRADE IS A HOLD

\$4,385

GOLD, BID ON THE WAR-AND-INFLATION PREMIUM BUT STILL BELOW ITS 28 JANUARY RECORD NEAR \$5,589

One force prices four instruments — the same dear money that lifts the yield lifts gold and leans on the rest.

HIGHER-FOR-LONGER

OIL-SHOCK REFLATION

DOLLAR BID

WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

A twin rate-and-oil headwind sits over global equities into the meeting, with a hawkish hike the live risk. Global bonds are capped while a five-per-cent ten-year is the anchor. Gold keeps a geopolitical and inflation-hedge bid, but range-bound under its January record. Bitcoin is trading as a risk asset — soft into the print, and running an unusually high correlation with gold. Explanation, not advice.²

CNBC; USAGOLD; TradingEconomics (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

The bond bulls have a case. Softer July jobs and retail-sales data argue for a hold, not a hike; Friday's oil fade and Monday's Muscat talks could deflate the reflation trade fast; and the EIA's ninety-dollar Brent forecast implies the inflation scare is transitory. If the Fed holds, everyone positioned for four-per-cent-plus is offside. Forecasts are forecasts, and this one cuts both ways.¹

SOURCES 1 — Federal News Network, USAGOLD, crypto.news/DeFiRate (11 Sep): FOMC 15–16 Sep, ~70–90% implied odds of a 25bp hike to 3.75–4.00%; Aug CPI +0.4% m/m / +3.4% y/y / core ~2.4%; hawkish chair. 2 — CNBC, TradingEconomics, Kitco/USAGOLD, Investing.com (11 Sep): Brent \$104.61; US 10-yr ~4.98%; gold ~\$4,385 (record ~\$5,589 on 28 Jan); BTC ~\$77k; DXy ~99.2; USD/JPY ~156.2; VWRA ~\$192; STI ~\$5,702; ECB to 2.50% (10 Sep). Market explanation and education, NOT investment advice; forecasts flagged as forecasts.

THE INVITATION • MODEL RAILWAYS

The oval on the table that becomes a world — four hobbies wearing one set of tracks

A layout starts as a locomotive, a few wagons and a circle of track in a box. It ends, for the properly hooked, as a room — because model railways are engineering, craft, collecting and operations at once, and each one has no bottom.

this story  

In the hobby's own words a "layout" is a diorama containing scale track for operating trains — and it runs from a shelf-top plank to builds that fill basements and whole buildings.¹ The reason it grips a certain kind of person is that it is four hobbies sharing one set of rails: the engineering of wiring and digital control, the craft of scenery and weathering, the collecting of locomotives, and the operations of running a railway to a timetable. You can enter through any one door and find the other three waiting.

The gateway is a train set — a loco, some cars, an oval and a controller in one box — and the modern hook is digital. By one industry estimate more than three-fifths of new electric train sets sold in 2025 shipped with digital control, and the moment that converts a buyer is the same every time: a locomotive that starts slowly, crawls at a realistic walking pace, and makes engine sound. The oval stops being a toy and becomes a place.¹

The scales sort the whole hobby by how much space you must surrender. **N**, at one to one-hundred-and-sixty, builds a real layout on a tabletop; **HO**, at one to eighty-seven, has been the world's most popular scale for over seventy-five years for its balance of detail and space; British **OO** is one to seventy-six; **O** is big and heavy; and **G** lives outdoors in the garden.² There is a famous British fudge here: OO and HO run on the *same* sixteen-and-a-half-millimetre track, but OO scales the body larger, so a British OO model carries a built-in gauge error of about twelve per cent — bodies a touch too fat for their rails, the price of using worldwide track.²

1:87

HO SCALE — "HALF O," THE WORLD'S MOST POPULAR MODEL-RAILWAY SCALE FOR OVER SEVENTY-FIVE YEARS, THE BEGINNER'S BALANCE OF DETAIL AND SPACE

THE GLOSSARY

Scale vs gauge — scale is the size ratio; gauge is the distance between the rails. **DC vs DCC** — DC powers the track (the loco with power moves); DCC (Digital Command Control) sends a signal that addresses each loco individually. **Decoder** — the chip inside a loco that reads DCC and drives sound and lights.

Rolling stock — the wagons that aren't the loco.

Consist — locos or cars coupled and run as one.

Staging / fiddle yard — hidden tracks where trains wait off-scene, so the visible railway has somewhere to run to.

Ballast — the scale gravel glued around the track.

Weathering — deliberately dirtying a model for realism.

Kitbashing — cutting up kits to build something new.

Fascia — the finished front edge of the layout.

The world behind the oval is large but greying, which is the tension the next two pages carry. The free monthly ezine *Model Railroad Hobbyist* reports an audience near seventy-seven thousand; the venerable *Model Railroader*, founded in 1934, still circulates well over a hundred thousand; and the American national body reported its members' average age at sixty-four in 2016, up from thirty-nine in the mid-1970s.¹ The counter-current is deliberate: Hornby launched a wholly new tabletop scale, TT, in 2022 — the first new model-railway scale in fifty years — aimed squarely at smaller homes and younger hands.²

SOURCES 1 — Wikipedia (Model railroad layout); MarkWide/Dataintel (vendor est.: ~61% of 2025 electric sets digital); model-railroad-hobbyist.com (MRH ~76,590 audience); Wikipedia (Model Railroader, founded 1934, circ. ~138k); TheHustle/NMRA (average member age 64 in 2016 vs 39 in the 1970s). 2 — WorldWideRails, trains.com, Wikipedia (scales Z/N/HO/OO/O/G; HO "most popular 75+ years"; OO 1:76.2 on 16.5mm = ~12.4% gauge error); uk.hornby.com (TT:120, Oct 2022, first new scale in 50 years). Vendor market figures are directional.

THE DEEP END • THE COMMUNITY, AND THE GEAR

Where the railway people gather — and the buy-once ladder, from a starter set to brass

The community splits along a few well-worn fault lines. Reddit's *r/modeltrains*, near a hundred and twenty-three thousand members, is the entry firehose — starter sets, glue, and lately 3D printers.¹ The British forum RMweb, running since 1999, is where prototype-fidelity and finescale debates live; the American mainstream orbits *Model Railroader* and the free *Model Railroad Hobbyist*, whose culture is operations and how-to.¹ On YouTube the tastemakers are specialists: Everard Junction for wiring and digital control, Luke Towan for scenery so real it embarrasses the trains, and Sam's Trains — past a hundred and sixty thousand subscribers — for the blunt “does it run out of the box” verdict the whole hobby actually wants.¹

THE CHATTER • THE COMMUNITY'S OWN ARGUMENTS

The running feuds tell you where the hobby's pressure sits: *rivet-counters versus runners* (prototype accuracy against “does it move”); *DC versus DCC* (cost and simplicity against features and sound); and the three-cornered scale culture of British OO, American HO and European. The consensus mechanical verdict, repeated across the forums: for a loco that just runs beautifully, Kato is number one, with Athearn Genesis, Rapido and Atlas close behind.¹

r/modeltrains; RMweb; modeltrainforum.com (as reported)

THE BUY-ONCE LADDER (2025–26 PRICES)

Quality entry. A Hornby OO starter set runs about seventy-two to three hundred and thirty pounds; Kato's N-scale sets are the reliable small-space on-ramp; and everyone graduates to Peco track (OO sections from about five pounds, N from under four). The supermarket toy-oval is a dead end — no upgrade path, so skip it.²

Sweet spot. Quality that runs: an Athearn Genesis diesel with DCC and sound lands near three hundred and fifty US dollars; ScaleTrains' “Rivet Counter” line is the accuracy leader at a price to match. For control, an NCE PowerCab (about a hundred and ninety-five dollars) or a Digitrax

Zephyr Express (about two hundred) is the entry, with ESU's LokSound the reference sound decoder since 1999.²

The tech-forward pick. DCC-EX — free open-source command-station firmware running on a cheap Arduino — is the natural door for a maker; the premium boxes climb through Roco's Wi-Fi Z21 to the ESU ECoS, called plainly “the best DCC system money can buy.”²

High end. European finescale is its own world — Märklin “in a league of its own,” Roco and Fleischmann the DC mainstream, Brawa with detail that rivals brass — while the traditional grail stays the hand-built Korean brass locomotive, imported one run at a time. But the modern high-detail plastic from ScaleTrains and Rapido now closes most of the gap at a fraction of the cost.²

~\$350

AN ATHEARN GENESIS DIESEL WITH DCC AND SOUND — THE SWEET-SPOT LOCOMOTIVE THAT STARTS THE COLLECTION IN EARNEST

THE SCEPTIC • THE QC REALITY

“Buy-once” does not guarantee “runs perfectly.” Even premium European names — Roco and Fleischmann — drew community complaints that quality dropped after production moved to China and Vietnam: ill-fitting add-on details, traction-tyre failures. The high-detail plastic from ScaleTrains and Rapido now rivals four-figure brass at a fraction of the price, so the honest advice is to buy the model that runs, not the one that gleams in a cabinet.²

Which brings the hobby to its quiet civil war — between the scenery builders and the operators. On one side sits the diorama craft that reviewers like Luke Towan have raised to an art: realistic water, hand-built structures, weathering that makes a new model look forty years used. On the other sits the operating culture of the free ezine crowd, who run their railways to a real timetable, dispatching trains between hidden staging yards as if a division of a real railroad depended on it. The best layouts are both at once, and the reader can enter through whichever door suits the week — a soldering iron, a paintbrush, or a laptop running the trains.¹

SOURCES 1 — gummysearch.com (*r/modeltrains* ~123k); rmweb.co.uk (est. 1999); trains.com, model-railroad-hobbyist.com; YouTube/vidIQ (Sam's Trains 160k+); modeltrainforum.com (Kato “number 1,” Athearn/Rapido/Atlas). 2 — railsofsheffield.com, petersspares.com (Hornby OO sets ~£72–328); peco-uk.com (track from ~£3.75/5.10); modeltrainforum.com (Athearn Genesis DCC+sound ~\$350; ScaleTrains Rivet Counter); modeltrains.ai/eurobahntrains.com (NCE PowerCab ~\$195, Digitrax Zephyr ~\$202, ESU ECoS); esu.eu (LokSound reference since 1999); dcc-ex.com (open-source). Prices as surfaced Sep 2026; verify at purchase.

THE DEEP END · THE GRAIL, THE CODE, AND THE WAY IN

Finescale obsessives, an open-source command station, and the honest ninety days

At the top the hobby stops chasing detail and starts chasing exactness. British finescale standards — P4, at an exact eighteen-point-eight-three-millimetre gauge, and EM at eighteen-point-two — exist to fix OO's gauge error, and the P4-versus-EM debate has run for decades on the Scalefour Forum and RMweb, with even its devotees admitting that a lot of people struggle to keep P4 wheels on P4 track.¹ The traditional grail above that is brass: hand-built in Korea by houses such as Samhongsang and Ajin, imported by Overland and Division Point, and often bought to own rather than run — individual locomotives trade from under a hundred dollars to well past nineteen hundred on the secondary market.¹

The custom tier is where the reader's two worlds meet. Enthusiasts sell 3D-printed detail parts through Shapeways and specialist shops; professional builders will construct a layout, a helix or a staging yard to commission; and the cutting edge is unmistakably digital. The open-source DCC-EX project runs a full command station on a cheap Arduino, with scripting to automate a railway and a server that turns a phone into a throttle; paired with the free JMRI software on a Raspberry Pi, it does decoder programming and whole operating sessions.¹ Roco's Wi-Fi Z21 does the ready-made version, its app driving thousands of decoders from a tablet.¹

\$5k–50k

THE COST OF A DETAILED PERMANENT HOME LAYOUT — AND A LAYOUT, THE HOBBY SAYS, IS NEVER FINISHED

THE FIRST NINETY DAYS

Weeks 1–4: lurk on r/modeltrains, RMweb and the free MRH ezine; watch Sam's Trains for out-of-the-box verdicts; decide your scale before you spend — in a flat, that means N or a small OO shelf.²

Weeks 5–8: buy one quality starter set (a Kato N or Hornby OO, roughly seventy to a hundred and thirty pounds) and extend it with Peco track; plan the track plan on graph

paper and test your longest train on your tightest curve before anything is glued.²

Weeks 9–12: add control — an NCE PowerCab or a Digitrax Zephyr, or for a maker a DCC-EX Arduino build — and one good locomotive with a LokSound decoder, the purchase that makes the railway feel alive. Build a plank, not an empire.²

THE SCEPTIC

The community says the hard parts out loud. It is a money pit — a layout runs from fifteen to several thousand dollars a square foot and is never done. Most people never get the basement: a sixty-by-thirty-centimetre board is micro territory, N or Z only. And DCC is a want, not a need, on a tiny layout — for one loco on a small oval, plain DC suffices; the digital payoff is sound and slow-speed finesse as you grow. The clearest warning came from the hobby itself: Britain's biggest show, Warley, closed in 2023, its organisers naming volunteers in their seventies with no young hands to take over.²

The Singapore reality is the space problem in sharp relief: a flat argues for N scale or a shelf layout, not a room. Stock comes in from the United Kingdom, the United States and Europe — Trains N Toys at the Orchard Hotel arcade and Hobby Bounties among the local names — so factor shipping and GST, and let the constraint be the design brief rather than the disappointment.²

NEXT DESCENTS · YOU PICK TOMORROW'S HOBBY

RC crawlers & bashers — radio-control off-road trucks built to crawl impossible rock or get gleefully smashed; the tech-tinkerer's mud-and-motors cousin.

Home fermentation (koji & miso) — cultivating mould and time into umami; patient microbiology you can eat, a jar-to-lab depth curve.

Urban sketching & watercolour — a pocket kit, a park bench, and the city drawn from life; the most portable craft on the bench.

SOURCES 1 — Wikipedia, scalefour.org, rmweb.co.uk (P4 18.83mm / EM 18.2mm; the P4-track admission); divisionpoint.com, trainz.com (Korean brass, Samhongsang/Ajin; secondary locos ~\$100–\$1,900+); shapeways.com (3D-print parts); dcc-ex.com, jmri.org (open-source command station, EXRAIL, WiThrottle, JMRI on Raspberry Pi); roco.cc/z21.eu (Wi-Fi Z21). 2 — innovativehobbysupply.com, quora.com (detailed layout \$5k–50k; \$15–\$7,000/sq ft; ~\$100/mo); charlesro.com (curves-too-tight / plan-first mistakes); therailab.com (60×30cm = N/Z micro); midwestmodelrr.com, trains.com (DC suffices on a small layout); trains.com/railadvent (Warley closed 2023, aging warning); modelrailforum.com, hobbybounties.com (SG: Trains N Toys, Hobby Bounties). Prices as surfaced Sep 2026; SG shops to confirm.

THE LONG GAME • THE GRIP AND THE ENGINE

Why a handshake predicts your decade — and why Zone 2 is a base, not a magic bullet

Two of the strongest longevity markers a mid-forties reader can actually train are grip strength and cardiorespiratory fitness. The 2026 research strengthens both — and quietly deflates the idea that slow cardio alone is enough.

this story 

The body keeps a reserve too, and two of its most telling gauges are cheap to read. A 2026 University at Buffalo study found older women in the highest grip-strength group had roughly a third lower risk of death than the lowest — independent of activity level, cardiovascular fitness and inflammation, meaning strength mattered even in those not meeting aerobic guidelines.¹ It sits on top of the large PURE cohort, where each five-kilogram drop in grip strength tracked about a sixteen-per-cent rise in all-cause mortality — a firmer signal than blood pressure for cardiovascular death.¹

The heavier gauge is the engine. In an analysis of a hundred and twenty-two thousand patients, low cardiorespiratory fitness carried a mortality risk comparable to smoking or diabetes — with no observed ceiling on the benefit of being fitter; moving from the bottom quartile to the middle roughly halves the risk.² The catch for the reader's age: peak aerobic capacity falls about ten per cent a decade from the thirties without training, and responds to it.

The practical programme that falls out of all this is unglamorous and short. Two full-body resistance sessions a week build and hold the muscle that grip strength is a proxy for; a few heavy carries or a timed dead-hang at the end of a session train the grip itself; a base of easy Zone 2 cardio builds the aerobic floor without wrecking recovery; and one or two hard interval sessions — the classic four-by-four minutes near maximum — move the capacity number that the slow work alone leaves flat. Then re-test once a year,

which for a reader already wearing a ring and a strap is a dashboard he owns rather than a lab he visits.²

~33%

LOWER MORTALITY FOR THE STRONGEST-GRIP GROUP IN THE 2026 BUFFALO STUDY — STRENGTH AS ITS OWN MARKER, NOT A PROXY FOR CARDIO

Grip is the cheapest longevity test there is: hang from a bar, and count.

THE LONGEVITY CHATTER

Peter Attia calls cardiorespiratory fitness the best single predictor of lifespan and champions dead-hangs as a field test for grip; he and Andrew Huberman have platformed both for years. A 2025 *Sports Medicine* review co-authored by Brad Schoenfeld questioned whether Zone 2 is uniquely effective, noting high-intensity intervals produce equal or larger capacity gains in roughly half the time — keep the slow base, but add the hard minutes.²

Peter Attia; Andrew Huberman; *Sports Medicine* (2025) (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC

These are associations, not proof that bolting on grip work buys years — grip is partly a proxy for total muscle, nutrition and biological age, and the Buffalo result is female-specific. The low-risk actions the whole field supports: two full-body resistance sessions a week with some heavy carries and hangs, a Zone 2 base, and periodic hard intervals — then re-test yearly. Don't chase a single biomarker of the month. General guidance, not medical advice.¹

SOURCES 1 — University at Buffalo (ScienceDaily, MedicalNewsToday, May 2026): highest grip-strength women ~33% lower mortality, independent of activity/fitness/inflammation (female cohort). PURE (~140,000): each 5kg grip drop ~16% higher all-cause mortality. 2 — Cooper Center / cardiorespiratory-fitness analysis (122,007 patients; low fitness ~ smoking/diabetes risk, no benefit ceiling); *Sports Medicine* (2025, Schoenfeld et al.: Zone 2 not uniquely effective, HIIT equal/larger VO2max gains); Attia/Huberman. General guidance, not medical advice.

DEPARTURES · WHAT CHANGED IN TRAVEL

Thailand shortens its welcome, Scoot adds a China city, and a new gate to Sydney opens

The weekend's most SG-relevant travel change lands the day this issue prints: Thailand cuts its visa-free stay in half. Plus new routes, a slipping SIA seat, and a strike weekend in Europe.

this story  

Start with the change that touches the most Singapore weekends. From Tuesday 15 September, Thailand cuts its visa-free stay for tourists from sixty days to thirty — Royal Gazette notices published on 31 August, confirmed by the tourism authority.¹ Singapore passports stay on the visa-exempt list, and the two-land-border-entries-a-year cap does not apply to Singaporeans, so the practical effect is simply a shorter free stay, live essentially the day you read this.¹

NEW ROUTES & GATES

Scoot → Guiyang. Singapore to Guiyang launches 26 October, three times a week on the A320neo, one-way economy from about a hundred and fifty-eight dollars — Scoot's sixteenth mainland-China city.¹

SIA → Western Sydney. Singapore Airlines becomes the first long-haul carrier at Western Sydney Airport, daily on the A350 from 23 November; and it is set to restore Madrid from late October via Barcelona — both worth confirming against SIA's newsroom before you book.¹

RTS Link. The Johor Bahru–Singapore rail link stays on track for a December 2026 passenger start — about ninety per cent built, a five-minute crossing — the delta this week being that it remains on schedule, no new milestone.¹

Two of those are worth a booking note now. The Guiyang launch adds a genuinely new south-western China gateway at a fare that undercuts a connection, and Western Sydney gives a Singapore flyer a second Sydney airport — useful precisely because it is on the city's growing west, closer to some suburbs than

Kingsford Smith. Both open in the next two months, which is when award space and launch fares are usually keenest.¹

30 days

THAILAND'S NEW VISA-FREE STAY FROM 15 SEP, DOWN FROM 60 — THE WEEKEND'S MOST PRACTICAL CHANGE

ALSO ON THE BOARD

The seat that keeps slipping. SIA's new A350 Business and First cabin retrofit has moved to the first quarter of 2027, from a 2026 slot — supply-chain and certification delays across forty-one aircraft, so don't book a long-haul expecting the new suite yet.²

Points, quietly cut. After last November's KrisFlyer devaluation, SIA trimmed its dynamic Access award rates again in March — up to about eleven per cent in economy — and the pre-devaluation Saver window has now essentially closed; spend miles on premium-cabin Saver space early.²

NEW ROUTE

ENTRY RULES

POINTS

THE CHATTER

On the points blogs (The MileLion, One Mile at a Time, AwardWallet) two frustrations recur: KrisFlyer's quiet second trim — after last November's devaluation, the dynamic Access award rates were cut again in March — with the standing advice to burn miles on premium Saver space early; and the SIA A350 cabin retrofit slipping to the first quarter of 2027, “the seat everyone's waiting for keeps moving right.”²

The MileLion; One Mile at a Time; AwardWallet (as reported)

SOURCES 1 — TAT Newsroom, LoyaltyLobby (Thailand 60 → 30-day visa-free from 15 Sep); AsiaOne, TripZilla (Scoot SIN–Guiyang, 26 Oct, from S\$158); singaporeheadline (SIA Western Sydney daily 23 Nov; Madrid via BCN late Oct — verify at newsroom); paultan.org, MOT (RTS Link ~90%, Dec 2026, 5-min crossing). 2 — The MileLion, AwardWallet (KrisFlyer Access trim, Mar 2026); One Mile at a Time (SIA A350 retrofit slip to Q1 2027). Items flagged “verify” are single-sourced.

DEPARTURES • RAIL, LOUNGES, ENTRY RULES

Japan's sleeper revival, a Changi rebuild, and a strike weekend to route around

Japan is quietly rebuilding romance into its rails. Private cabins arrive on select Tokaido Shinkansen from October; the “Tokaido Lumière Express,” an overnight sleeper-Shinkansen package, made its first run in August; and JR East is preparing a new Tokyo-Tohoku private-cabin sleeper.¹ One caution for pass-holders: the Japan Rail Pass rises again on 1 October — but only through travel agents; buy on the official JR site and the current price holds.¹

LOUNGES, CABINS & ENTRY

Changi, private side. The JetQuay private terminal is being redeveloped by Changi Airport Group and Plaza Premium into a new premium terminal — lounge, bar, suites, dining — targeted for mid-2027; SIA's new First Class SilverKris Lounge opened late last year.¹

Cabins in flux. ANA is rolling “The Room FX” onto the 787-9 through 2026; United's redesigned Polaris Studio debuts on new 787-9s, early routes including San Francisco–Singapore.¹

Europe entry. The biometric Entry/Exit System has been live since April, replacing passport stamping; the ETIAS travel authorisation is now confirmed not before 2027. Japan's tripled departure tax — three thousand yen — is live and bundled into fares (a reminder only; covered last week).¹

Japan tax-free, reformed. The shift to a refund-at-departure model for tax-free shopping is still slated for 1 November — you pay the consumption tax at the till and reclaim it leaving the country, so keep receipts and build in airport time; a delta only, tracked since last week.¹

Regional entry, in brief. Bali's tourist levy remains in force, and several ASEAN neighbours continue to tune entry rules — check the specific country a fortnight out rather than trusting last year's memory, the same discipline the Thailand change on the facing page rewards.¹

Hokkaido bed. Hyatt Centric makes its Hokkaido debut in Sapporo late this year — ski-country relevance, and a natural pairing with the Diary's Sapporo snow festival (p23).¹

The bigger 2026 hotel story is Kyoto, which has quietly filled with openings for the traveller who books ahead: 1 Hotel Tokyo landed in Akasaka in the spring, and in Kyoto both Capella (a Kengo Kuma build in Miyagawa-cho) and an Imperial Hotel inside the Yasaka Kaikan in Gion opened within weeks of each other — the sort of scarcity that repays a reservation months out, and cross-references The Good Life's buy-once-escape instinct.¹

Q1 '27

THE NEW SIA A350 CABIN'S SLIPPED DEBUT — ONE MORE REASON TO CHECK THE SEAT MAP, NOT THE BROCHURE, BEFORE BOOKING

THE CHATTER

On the rail forums the sleeper revival is read as nostalgia meeting yield management: the private-cabin Shinkansen and the overnight Lumière package are premium products aimed at travellers who now treat the journey as the trip, not the transfer — and, the threads note, a neat hedge against a rising Japan Rail Pass that pushed casual users off the flat-rate deal.¹

Japan-rail forums; SoraNews24 (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC • A STRIKE WEEKEND

Europe's September strike season bites exactly now: Italy has aviation strikes on 13 September — Rome Fiumicino and Ciampino security — and another nationwide walkout on the 30th, with French action alongside. If you are transiting Rome or a French hub this weekend, check status before you leave for the airport, and build in a buffer; a printed itinerary is not a boarding pass when the ground staff walk.²

¥3,000

JAPAN'S TRIPLED “SAYONARA” DEPARTURE TAX, NOW LIVE AND FOLDED INTO YOUR FARE

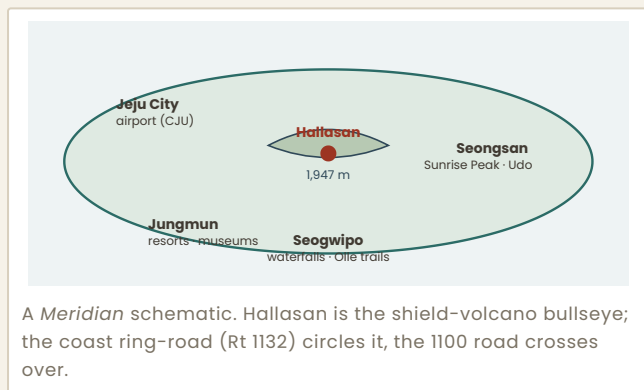
SOURCES 1 — SoraNews24, Japan Today (Tokaido private cabins Oct; Lumière Express sleeper Aug; JR East Tohoku sleeper); japan-guide/jrpass (JR Pass rise 1 Oct, agents only); The MileLion, Future Travel Experience (Changi JetQuay redevelopment ~mid-2027; SilverKris First); Simple Flying (ANA Room FX; United Polaris Studio); Euronews (Hyatt Centric Sapporo late 2026); EC/Fragomen (EES live, ETIAS 2027); Travel Voice (Japan ¥3,000 departure tax). 2 — Connexion France, MyFlyRight (Italy aviation strikes 13 & 30 Sep; French action).

THE GRAND TOUR • JEJU ISLAND, SOUTH KOREA

The island Koreans keep for themselves once the summer crowds go home

Jeju is Korea's mass-tourism engine, not a hidden gem — but time it for late October and it turns into something else: a volcanic island of autumn foliage, sunrise peaks and women who still dive it by hand.

Jeu rewards a calendar more than a checklist. The connoisseur's window is late October: the summit foliage on Hallasan peaks around the twentieth to the thirtieth, the coastal lowlands not until early November, so a single climb crosses several stages of autumn at once, under clear fifteen-to-twenty-five-degree skies and thinner crowds.¹ Spring brings the yellow canola around Seongsan; the months to *avoid* are the domestic peak of late July and August — extreme heat, peak typhoon risk, jammed beaches — and the Chuseok holiday, which in 2026 falls on the 24th to 26th of September and sells out everything.¹



Getting there is easy in both shapes. Scoot has flown Singapore to Jeju nonstop since 2022 — about six hours, with Singapore Airlines and T'way also direct — or you fly to Seoul and hop the Gimpo-Jeju shuttle, the world's busiest air route, with a flight every ten minutes.² One honest correction to the “cheap Korea” reflex: the won has firmed roughly nine per cent against the Singapore dollar over six months — about a thousand and sixty won to the dollar now — so Jeju is no longer the bargain it was, though still gentler on the ground than Japan.²

~6 hrs

SINGAPORE TO JEJU NONSTOP ON SCOOT — OR VIA SEOUL'S GIMPO-JEJU SHUTTLE, A FLIGHT ROUGHLY EVERY TEN MINUTES

Base yourself deliberately. The island splits into five zones; for a family of a few nights, either split two bases — Jeju City in the north for the food and the airport, Seogwipo in the south for the waterfalls and the calmer evenings — or anchor in the Jungmun resort cluster, which has the pools a twelve-year-old wants, and day-trip out.³ The trade-off is real: two bases kill the repeated cross-island drives but cost you a packing day; a single southern base keeps evenings slow but turns the far east into a long haul. For a first visit of five or six nights, most trip reports land on Seogwipo plus one or two nights in the east near Seongsan, so the sunrise climb is a short pre-dawn drive rather than an hour in the dark.³

~1,058

KOREAN WON TO THE SINGAPORE DOLLAR — UP ABOUT 9% IN SIX MONTHS, SO PRICE JEJU AS A MID-COST TRIP, NOT A BARGAIN

One planning note that changes the whole trip: because the marquee sights are ticketed and time-managed and the roads are rural, Jeju rewards a loose itinerary built around the weather forecast rather than a fixed list. Locals treat a clear morning as the cue to climb or drive the coast, and a wet one as the day for the lava tube, the museums and the cafes — the deep end overleaf sorts the sights that earn the trip from the ones that fill a rainy afternoon.¹

SOURCES 1 — Korea Insider, Seoulcut, PublicHolidays.co.kr: late-Oct foliage window (Hallasan ~20–30 Oct), spring canola, avoid Jul–Aug (heat/typhoon/crowds) and Chuseok (24–26 Sep 2026). 2 — Skyscanner, OAG, Simple Flying (Scoot SIN-CJU nonstop since 2022 ~6h; SIA/T'way direct; Gimpo-Jeju world's busiest route); Pluang/valutafx (~1 SGD ≈ 1,058 KRW, won +-9% vs SGD over 6 months). 3 — Korea Insider, The Soul of Seoul (basing zones: Jeju City / Seogwipo / Seongsan / Jungmun / Aewol). Forum sentiment flagged as chatter overleaf.

THE GRAND TOUR · JEJU, THE DEEP END

The peak, the divers and the black pork — and what the forums actually say

The signature experiences earn their place, with one caveat each. Hallasan's crater-lake summit is reachable only by the Seongpanak or Gwaneumsa trails, and only with a free advance reservation on the official booking system — a QR code scanned at the gate, a three-month ban for a no-show — so book it before you fly.¹ Seongsan Ilchulbong, the tuff cone on the cover, is a short steep climb to a UNESCO-listed sunrise; Manjanggul is a cool, flat, kid-proof lava tube for a wet day; and the Olle trails thread the coast for those who'd rather walk than tick.¹

The most moving encounter is not a sight but a vanishing craft. The *haenyeo* — the women free-divers of Jeju, a UNESCO intangible heritage — have dwindled to around twenty-six hundred, some ninety per cent of them over sixty, many in their seventies and eighties, diving to ten metres without air.¹ Watch the morning dives and eat what they bring up at a *haenyeo* house; it is real, not staged. The food beyond it is the island's black pork — the native black-haired pig, densest on Black Pig Street near Dongmun Market — grilled galchi hairtail, abalone porridge, and the sweet hallabong citrus, best picked October to January.²

Beyond the headline sights, the island's texture is in its smaller moves. The Olle trails — a network of coastal walking routes — give you the island at three kilometres an hour; the oreum, the hundreds of grassy parasitic cones, are easy climbs that turn silver with eoksae grass in late October; a short ferry reaches Udo for a day of bikes and the view back to Seongsan; and three waterfalls around Seogwipo, one of them dropping straight into the sea, reward a morning. None of it needs a ticket queue, which is exactly why the regulars rate it above the marquee stops.¹

~2,600

HAENYEO DIVERS LEFT ON JEJU, ~90% OF THEM OVER SIXTY
— A HERITAGE YOU CAN STILL WATCH, BUT NOT FOR MANY
MORE YEARS

FAMILY LOGISTICS & MONEY

A car is effectively required — sights are rural and spread out. Singaporeans need a physical International Driving Permit from AA Singapore (about twenty dollars, issued on the spot), the physical home licence, and the passport; digital copies are not accepted, and you drive on the right.²

Budget about a hundred and forty US dollars per person per day mid-range — a family of three over five nights lands near two to two-and-a-half thousand on the ground, ex-flights; the firmer won means budgeting a little more than older guides suggest.²

The architecture add-on. For a design-minded traveller, the island hides a trio of Tadao Ando concrete-and-light buildings — the Genius Loci and Bonte museums and the Glass House — that reward a half-day the way the volcanic sights reward a clear morning; genuinely worth it, and quiet even in season.¹

WHAT THE FORUMS ACTUALLY SAY

The consensus on r/korea and the TripAdvisor Jeju board is near-unanimous on one point — rent a car — with a well-shared dissent (a Medium trip-report arguing buses and taxis suffice if you base centrally and slow down). The louder minority grumble is “overrated / too developed”: reviewers note the marquee sights charge entry and can feel over-managed, and that “two or three days is enough” for the headline list. And everyone warns about weather.³

r/korea; TripAdvisor Jeju forum; trip-report blogs (summarised, attributed)

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE THE WISDOM IS WRONG

Two received ideas to drop. First, “cheap Korea”: the won has firmed against the Singapore dollar, so price it like a mid-cost trip, not a bargain. Second, that summer is the time to go — it is the worst, stacking heat, typhoons and domestic crowds. Autumn is the insider season, and the honest counsel is not to gamble Jeju in a bad-weather window: keep a rainy-day list of caves, museums and cafes, and the island rewards you.³

SOURCES 1 — VisitJeju, UNESCO (WHC #1264 Seongsan/Hallasan/Geomunoreum; ICH *haenyeo* 2016; ~2,600 divers, ~90% over 60); Hallasan Booking System (Seongpanak/Gwaneumsa reservation, QR gate, no-show ban); Manjanggul; Olle trails. 2 — Korea Insider, Hey K-Travel (black pork/Black Pig St, galchi, abalone, hallabong Oct–Jan); AA Singapore/YouTrip (IDP ~\$20, physical docs, drive on right); BudgetYourTrip 2026 (~US\$140 pp/day). 3 — r/korea, TripAdvisor Jeju forum, trip-report blogs (rent-a-car consensus; overrated/too-developed dissent; weather; “cheap Korea” myth vs firmer won). Forum sentiment summarised, not quoted; hard claims verified.

WHAT'S WORTH BOOKING • THE DATED AGENDA

A Grand Prix with a Sprint, a snow festival to fly for, and Westlife's return

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW • PLAN AHEAD

- 10 OCT

★ F1 Singapore Grand Prix — first-ever Sprint

9–11 OCT • MARINA BAY STREET CIRCUIT • THE SEASON'S FINAL SPRINT ROUND
- 10 OCT

The Killers — Padang stage

AFTER SAT QUALIFYING • PART OF THE GP ENTERTAINMENT
- 11 OCT

Lana Del Rey — Singapore debut

AFTER THE RACE • THE PADANG • FIRST SG SHOW
- 17–18 OCT

BIGBANG

NATIONAL STADIUM • 18 OCT ADDED
- 16 JAN

★ Westlife — “25” Anniversary Tour

INDOOR STADIUM • 16 JAN SOLD OUT; 17 JAN ADDED, S\$138–328
- 22–24 JAN

Art SG 2027 + Singapore Art Week

SANDS EXPO, MBS • SAW ISLANDWIDE 21–31 JAN, MANY FREE
- 13–18 APR

Bruno Mars — The Romantic Tour

NATIONAL STADIUM • GENERAL SALE MON 14 SEP, 10AM, TICKETMASTER
- 10–11 NOV

My Chemical Romance

NATIONAL STADIUM • SOLD OUT • RESALE ONLY
- 25 NOV

Guns N' Roses

NATIONAL STADIUM • THE REUNION LINE-UP
- 19 Sep–22 Nov

Deepavali light-up, Little India

SERANGOON RD • FREE • A FAMILY EVENING WALK

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

- 04 FEB

★ Sapporo Snow Festival

4–11 FEB 2027 • ODORI/SUSUKINO/TSU DOME, HOKKAIDO • FAMILY SNOW SLIDES; BOOK FLIGHTS & HOTELS NOW
- Nov–Feb

Marunouchi Winter Illuminations

CENTRAL TOKYO • MID-NOV 2026 – MID-FEB 2027 • FREE
- 14 Nov–28 Mar

Orsay masterpieces @ Tokyo Met

TOKYO METROPOLITAN ART MUSEUM • ADVANCE TICKETS 28 SEP
- 08–22 NOV

Kyushu Basho (grand sumo)

FUKUOKA • ON-SALE 19 SEP • A BUCKET-LIST FLY-FOR
- 25 Nov–06 Dec

Rikugien night illumination

TOKYO • AUTUMN-LEAVES LIGHT-UP IN AN EDO GARDEN

PLANNING NOTES

Book tomorrow: Bruno Mars goes to general sale Monday 14 September at 10am on Ticketmaster (up to six per transaction) for April 2027 — presale buyers already in.¹ **Family-coded:** the Sapporo festival's Tsu Dome site has snow slides and sledding built for a twelve-year-old, and pairs with the Hyatt Centric opening (p20); the F1 Sprint means track action every day, not just Sunday.¹ **Do not confuse:** Stray Kids play Kaohsiung, not Singapore, this December — and Gardens by the Bay's Christmas Wonderland 2026 dates are not yet official, so hold.¹

SingaporeGP; Live Nation SG; The Kallang / Ticketmaster SG; sapporo.travel (verified still-on)

SOURCES 1 — SingaporeGP/Formulal.com (F1 SG GP 9–11 Oct, first Sprint; Killers 10 Oct; Lana Del Rey debut 11 Oct); The Kallang/Ticketmaster SG (BIGBANG 17–18 Oct; Westlife 16–17 Jan 2027, 16 sold out, 17 S\$138–328); artsg.com/artweek.sg (Art SG 22–24 Jan, SAW 21–31 Jan); Live Nation SG (Bruno Mars 13–18 Apr 2027, gen sale 14 Sep); sapporo.travel/japan-guide (Sapporo Snow Festival 4–11 Feb 2027); japantravel (Marunouchi illuminations); Tokyo Met/tobikan.jp (Orsay, advance 28 Sep); Ticket Oosumo (Kyushu Basho 8–22 Nov). All re-verified still-on; Post Malone remains cancelled and is not listed.

THE TABLE • SINGAPORE'S NEWEST COUNTERS

A Fujian import with a queue, a Michelin chef's casual second act, and a garden glasshouse reborn

The strongest pedigree opening of the season is the quietest. **Assaggi**, on Neil Road since 10 August, is the second concept from Denis Lucchi of the one-Michelin-starred Buona Terra — a “fine-casual” Italian pitched between his flagship and his Locanda, philosophy “imperfect by choice.” It runs set menus only: a three-course lunch at fifty-eight dollars, two dinner tasting journeys — the Signature and the Pasta — at eighty-eight, with supplements. The room is small and open Tuesday to Saturday, so book well ahead; on pedigree alone it is the season's one to beat.¹

Linkus, the second Singapore outlet of an award-winning Minnan restaurant from Xiamen, opened in August at Takashimaya on Orchard. Under a head chef of twenty years, it coaxes sweetness from premium seafood with restrained Southern Fujian technique — a Xiamen abalone taro bun at under thirteen dollars, a Yong'an yellow-chilli grouper around seventy-nine a fish. When the Suntec original opened earlier this year it drew long queues and packed weeknights, so reserve to skip the wait. Not halal.¹

Tembusu takes over the Botanic Gardens glasshouse that was long The Halia — a soft-launch that opened officially on 3 September, from the Fleursophy group's Nicole Chen, serving what it calls “Straits maximalism”: Malay-Peranakan-Southeast-Asian cooking inside a UNESCO garden, breakfast from twelve dollars, and it is pet-friendly. It is too new to call on the food, but the address is one of Singapore's most coveted, and it makes a natural weekend family brunch after a Gardens walk. Halal status is unconfirmed — check with the venue before you plan around it.¹

THE BUZZ • WHAT THE REVIEWERS SAY

The local food press — HungryGoWhere, FACT, City Nomads on Assaggi; Daniel Food Diary, Eatbook and Miss Tam Chiak on Linkus; Ordinary Patrons and SETHLUI on Tembusu — reads the season as pedigree-heavy: a Michelin chef going casual, a cult regional import scaling up, and a landmark address changing hands. The verdict on the food itself, for the two newest, is a careful “too soon,” with the pedigree doing the early talking.²

HungryGoWhere; Eatbook; Ordinary Patrons; SETHLUI (as reported)

THE SCEPTIC • THE RESERVATION REALITY

Two honest cautions. A landmark address is not a landmark meal — the old Halia coasted for years on its glasshouse setting, and Tembusu will be judged on the plate once the soft-launch glow fades. And the “too new to call” label is not a hedge but the point: the food press hasn't eaten enough to rate the two newest rooms, so treat opening-week praise as pedigree, not verdict, and let the queue for Linkus be a fact rather than a promise.²

ALSO OPEN, WORTH A LOOK

Foura — a wellness-led glasshouse at Gardens by the Bay (opened July) built around “Blue Zones” longevity eating, contemporary Asian-European mains twenty-eight to forty-six dollars; the fifty outdoor seats at sunset are the ones to request — and a rare Table pick that speaks to the Fitness desk's week.¹

Behind Clay — Ciro Sorrentino, late of Margheri in Ho Chi Minh City, brings wood-fired Neapolitan cooking to town (August); one for the pizza obsessive rather than the occasion.²

Mom's Touch — Korea's largest fried-chicken chain returns to Singapore this month; not a destination meal, but a genuinely family-friendly, wallet-light option after a mall afternoon.²

The through-line of the season is pedigree over novelty — a Michelin chef going casual, a cult regional import scaling up, a landmark address changing hands — which is the good kind of problem for a diner: the risk is a full book, not a bad meal. Reserve the two you actually want, and let the rest wait for the reviews.²

NEIL ROAD

ORCHARD

BOTANIC GARDENS

SOURCES 1 — HungryGoWhere, FACT, City Nomads (Assaggi, 77A Neil Rd, 10 Aug; Denis Lucchi/Buona Terra; set menus S\$58/88++); Daniel Food Diary, Eatbook, Miss Tam Chiak (Linkus/临家, Takashimaya #04-22, Aug; Xiamen Minnan; queues); HungryGoWhere, Ordinary Patrons, SETHLUI (Tembusu, Botanic Gardens ex-Halia, official 3 Sep; Fleursophy/Nicole Chen; brunch from S\$12; halal unconfirmed); The Peak, Tatler (Foura, Gardens by the Bay, Jul; Blue Zones, mains S\$28-46). 2 — local food-media & forum synthesis as cited; verdicts flagged “too new to call” where rooms just opened.

THE UNDERCURRENT · INDIA

Streedhan goes to work

India is quietly liquefying its last taboo asset. The family gold — a woman's own, inherited mother to daughter — is being turned into working cash at industrial scale, and the shame has flipped to savvy. It is 1991, rerun at the scale of the household.

this story 

Streedhan — a woman's own gold, gifted at marriage or passed mother to daughter, legally and culturally hers — has always been the Indian household's shadow central bank: a store of value in a country without much of a welfare net, worn on the wrist and the neck rather than banked.¹ Its cardinal rule was that you did not touch it. To pledge the family jewellery, and above all the *mangalsutra*, the marriage necklace, was a mark of ruin. That rule is dissolving — not quietly in distress, but loudly and on television, reframed as sophisticated finance.

The scale is hard to overstate. Indian households hold something like thirty-four thousand six hundred tonnes of gold — around three-point-eight trillion dollars, nearly ninety per cent of the country's GDP.¹ Against that hoard, lending is booming. Loans against gold jewellery reached roughly five-and-a-half lakh crore rupees by July, nearly double a year earlier; by the Reserve Bank's own tally, gold loans more than doubled to about four trillion rupees — forty-three billion dollars — in a year.¹ The gold-loan book has grown almost fourfold since 2022 to become India's second-largest retail credit product.¹

The sovereign once did this in shame and secrecy. Tens of millions of households now do it routinely, and on camera.

Two things drive it. One is the price: gold crossed a hundred and fifty thousand rupees for ten grams for the first time this year, its index up some hundred and forty-four per cent in two years, so the same bangles now borrow far more — the average loan

ticket has roughly doubled to nearly two lakh rupees since 2023, on the same jewellery.² The other is who is at the centre of it. Women hold about forty-three-and-a-half per cent of gold loans outstanding — the highest share of any credit product in India, above education and home loans.²

Behind the numbers is a structural fact about how Indian households save. Gold is the family's shadow central bank in a country with a thin welfare net — a store of value that holds its worth through inflation and rupee weakness, that is liquid in any bazaar, and that has, until now, sat idle in a locker earning nothing. What the boom does is put that idle reserve to work: a loan-to-value of up to seventy-five per cent against jewellery, at rates well below an unsecured personal loan, with the gold returned when the loan is repaid. The specialist non-bank lenders have grown their book almost fourfold since 2022, at a compound rate roughly twice the pace of the rest of retail credit — which is why Muthoot Finance and Manappuram have become market darlings rather than pawnbrokers.¹

And the culture around it has been deliberately turned. Pledging gold was, within living memory, a private humiliation — the thing a family did in the dark, ashamed. The lenders have spent real money to make it feel like prudence instead, and the reframing has largely worked: a distress instrument has been rebranded as a liquidity tool, and the shame has migrated from the act of pledging to the idea of leaving wealth unused.²

43.5%

WOMEN'S SHARE OF INDIA'S GOLD LOANS — THE HIGHEST OF ANY CREDIT PRODUCT, AND THE ESSAY'S CENTRAL QUESTION IN ONE NUMBER

SOURCES 1 — Morgan Stanley (Oct 2025: households ~34,600t gold, ~\$3.8tn, ~89% GDP); The Wire/PTI (loans vs jewellery ~₹5.52 lakh crore Jul 2026 vs ₹2.93 a year earlier); RBI via Reuters (gold loans >doubled to ~₹4tn / \$43.3bn); TransUnion CIBIL (~3.8× since Mar 2022, India's 2nd-largest retail credit product). Definition of "streedhan" per Indian legal/cultural usage. 2 — Tribune (gold >₹1,50,000/10g; index +144% Mar 2024–Mar 2026; avg ticket ₹1.96 lakh FY26 vs ₹98,000 FY23); CRIF/BusinessToday (women 43.5% of gold-loan outstandings).

The de-stigmatisation is engineered as much as it is organic. Muthoot Finance runs a campaign, “Sunheri Soch” — golden thinking — narrated by Amitabh Bachchan, built explicitly to break the shame of pledging; a fintech lender’s tagline runs, “Stridhan was always hers. Now it’s working for her.”¹ Borrowers, the trade press reports, increasingly see a gold loan “not as a distress option, but as a smart financial tool for short-term liquidity.” The lenders’ own share prices tell the market’s view: Muthoot up nearly half over the year, Manappuram a quarter, the industry forecast to pass thirty lakh crore rupees by 2028.¹

There is a precedent for a country reaching for its gold, and it is the essay’s spine. In the balance-of-payments crisis of 1991, with reserves down to about three weeks of imports, India pledged sixty-seven tonnes of gold to raise a little over two billion dollars — forty-seven tonnes airlifted to the Bank of England and the Bank of Japan, twenty more sold to a Swiss bank in a night-time repo kept secret because the publicity of a nation pawning its gold risked panic.² The state did once, in shame and in the dark, exactly what tens of millions of households now do routinely and in daylight. That inversion — from national humiliation to household normalcy — is what the trend actually means.

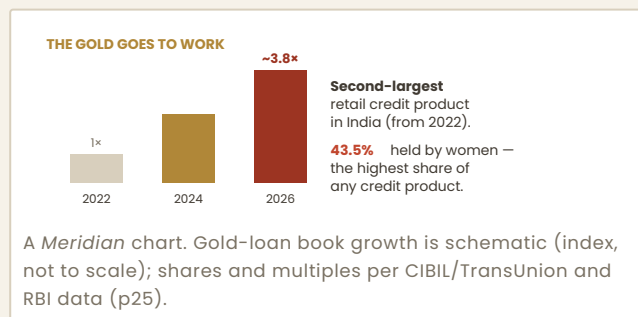
Is this women’s financial agency, or the quiet pawning of the household’s last sacred asset? The honest answer is both.

The politics have noticed. The opposition leader Mallikarjun Kharge turned the numbers into a charge last year — “your ‘mangalsutra’ remarks have come true” — claiming four crore women had mortgaged gold worth four-point-seven lakh crore rupees over five years, and blaming demonetisation and inflation for gutting the household reserve.¹ The mangalsutra at the pawn counter is the emotional core, and it is why a dry credit statistic carries the charge of a morality tale.

The symmetry with 1991 is what makes the trend legible rather than merely large. Then, the shame was the state’s, and the secrecy was the point — a proud country could not be seen pawning its gold to strangers, so it did so at night, and the governor who signed it off spent years defending a decision that in fact averted a default. Now the same transaction is a billboard: Amitabh Bachchan narrates it, a fintech app celebrates it, and a woman is told her inheritance was “always hers” and can now “work for her.” The distance travelled is not economic — the mechanics are identical — but cultural. A society has decided that reaching for the reserve is no longer a confession.²

The transaction itself is almost mundane, which is part of what has normalised it. A woman brings her bangles to a branch or, increasingly, to a doorstep agent; the gold is weighed and assayed while she waits; a loan of up to three-quarters of its value is disbursed to her phone in minutes; and the jewellery goes into a sealed packet in the vault, to be returned when she repays. There is no credit check, because the gold is the credit. That speed and dignity — no forms, no judgement, her own asset — is precisely what the lenders sell, and precisely what makes the reserve so easy to reach for.¹

Whether that is progress or its opposite depends on a question the loan book cannot answer: is the gold going to work because families have grown confident enough to use a lazy asset, or because the month no longer stretches and the locker is the only thing left to open? The lenders’ share prices — Muthoot up nearly half in a year, the industry tipped to pass thirty lakh crore rupees by 2028 — price the optimistic reading.¹ The next page tests it.



SOURCES 1 — Outlook Business (“no longer a last resort”); Muthoot “Sunheri Soch” (Amitabh Bachchan) & indiagold tagline; CNBC/Business Standard (Muthoot +~47%, Manappuram +~24%; industry to >₹30 lakh crore by 2028); The Tribune/The Statesman/National Herald (Kharge: 4cr women, ₹4.7 lakh crore, mangalsutra charge). 2 — Business Standard, Stanford Intersect (1991 crisis: 67t pledged, ~\$2.2bn IMF facility, ~46.9t airlifted to BoE/BoJ, ~20t secret UBS repo, RBI Gov Venkitaramanan).

Before the moral becomes too clean, the numbers deserve the sceptic they require. “Gold loans” means different things in different mouths — NBFC-only, banks-plus-NBFC, or the whole system including agricultural gold loans — which is why the figures range from three-and-a-quarter lakh crore to five-and-a-half to well past thirteen trillion depending on the source.¹ The Reserve Bank itself flags that much of the “growth” is existing customers topping up and rolling over as prices rise, plus farm loans reclassified into the gold bucket after regulatory scrutiny. A good deal of the headline surge is collateral revaluation, not new borrowers.¹

The empowerment reading is fragile too. Women’s forty-three-per-cent share may reflect not agency but the plain fact that streedhan is the most pledgeable asset a squeezed household owns — distress wearing the language of finance. Delinquency has fallen — ninety-plus-day defaults down to around two-tenths of a per cent — but short tenors, rollovers and auction mechanics can mask stress as easily as prove health, and household debt hit a record share of GDP by the end of last year, roughly half of it for consumption rather than for assets that build wealth.¹ The de-stigmatisation, remember, is partly a sales campaign; the loudest distress figure is a political claim with an unclear base.²

There is a tail risk hiding in the collateral itself. The whole edifice rests on a gold price that has run up a hundred and forty-four per cent in two years; a book grown fat on revaluation is a book exposed to revaluation in reverse. A sharp fall in the metal would leave loans underwater against jewellery families cannot bear to lose, and the Reserve Bank has already begun tightening loan-to-value and classification rules precisely because it can see the concentration building. The comfort is that gold rarely falls the way it rises; the discomfort is that a nation has quietly made its most emotional asset the collateral for its monthly shortfalls.¹

So hold both truths at once, which is the only honest place to land. This is financial sophistication — a real asset, legally a woman’s own, put to work at a fair loan-to-value instead of sitting idle in a locker — and it is quiet distress, a nation’s households reaching for the reserve because the wage and the state do not stretch far enough. The mangalsutra on the counter is both a woman’s money finally moving and a family’s last line being drawn down. When a society stops trusting that the future will provide, its most private store of value becomes its working capital — and that, not the loan book, is the number that should give a reader pause.²

When a society stops trusting the future to provide, its most private reserve becomes its working capital.

There is a reason this matters beyond India, and beyond the credit cycle. Gold is the asset a household reaches for when it has stopped trusting the paper claims — the wage, the pension, the state’s promise — to hold their value. That the reflex is firing now, at the household level, in the fastest-growing large economy on earth, is a signal worth reading alongside the same metal’s record run in the world’s central-bank vaults (the Macro Desk’s week, [p14](#)). When both the sovereign and the citizen are quietly loading up on the oldest reserve there is, they are answering the same question about the future, in the same direction.²

India has done this before, at the top. What is new is that it is now happening at the bottom, at scale, and without shame — which is either a country growing financially confident, or one quietly running down the one thing it kept for the worst day. The Long Read’s wager is that, a few weeks from now, the same trend will be discovered by the outlets that missed it — and that the honest framing will still be the uncomfortable one: both, at once.²

SOURCES 1 — RBI commentary via Deccan Herald/Outlook: definitional spread in “gold loans” (NBFC vs system vs agri); much growth = top-ups/rollovers + reclassified farm loans (collateral revaluation, not new demand); 90+ DPD fell to ~0.2% (Mar 2026) but masking risks; household debt ~47.8% of GDP (Dec 2025), ~half consumption. 2 — Meridian analysis; de-stigmatisation as partly a lender campaign (Muthoot Sunheri Soch); Kharge’s 4-crore figure a political claim with unclear base. Under-radar check: no NYT/BBC/Reuters/FT/CNN/Guardian feature on the streedhan-as-collateral society angle at time of writing (Reuters markets-wire figures and a CNBC newsletter only).

M E R I D I A N

THE LAST WORD

What the reserve is for

A reserve is not wealth; it is the option wealth buys — the choice to not act in a bad week. This issue watched that option get spent from both ends: a Fed leaning on the price of money, and, in India, tens of millions of families turning the gold on their wrists into cash because the month ran short. Between them sit the buy-once desks, quietly arguing the other case — that the surest reserve is owning one good thing that lasts, and reaching for it less. Seneca had the whole ledger in nine words: it is the craving, not the having-too-little, that makes a man poor.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

SOURCES, THIS ISSUE — World/Macro: CNBC, EnergyNow, Anadolu, Al Jazeera, Fox News, Kyiv Independent, EIA, Goldman Sachs, TradingEconomics, USAGOLD. Singapore: NEA, Malay Mail, Mothership, The Star, FMT. Atelier: Permanent Style, StyleForum, Nathan Tailors, VBC, Suitsupply, Edit Suits, CYC. Technology: CNBC, Big Hat Group, TrendForce, FT, WSJ, Hugging Face, AI Weekly, Tom's Hardware. Kit/Good Life: Android Headlines, ecoustics, Citizen newsroom, Watchonista, WatchTime. Screen: Euronews, Variety, Hollywood Reporter, La Biennale, Clash. Family/Fitness: Mothership, NBER, Nature portfolio, Manchester, ScienceDaily, PURE, Sports Medicine, Attia, Huberman. Travel: TAT, AsiaOne, The MileLion, VisitJeju, UNESCO, OAG. Diary: SingaporeGP, Live Nation SG, Ticketmaster SG, HungryGoWhere, Eatbook. Long Read: Morgan Stanley, RBI/Reuters, TransUnion CIBIL, CRIF, The Tribune, Outlook Business, Business Standard. Full per-page sources on each desk. Figures as reported by the named outlets; unverifiable numbers held, not invented.